

Is Mom or Dad okay living alone?

30 things worth noticing. A checklist for adult children.

A list of things worth noticing, for the visit where everything looks fine and you still drive home uneasy. There's no score at the bottom.

Answer for how things are now compared with a year ago. One check mark means nothing on its own. Three or four in the same section is worth a conversation, with them or with their doctor. Fill it in afterwards, not in front of them.

Food and the kitchen

- ☐ 1. There's food gone bad in the fridge, or very little food in it at all.
- ☐ 2. They're eating the same one or two simple things every day.
- ☐ 3. Pans, the stove or the microwave show signs of something burned.
- ☐ 4. They've lost or gained noticeable weight since you last saw them.
- ☐ 5. Cooking has quietly stopped, and it used to be something they did.

The house

- ☐ 6. Dishes, laundry or trash are piling up in a way they never used to.
- ☐ 7. Something has been broken for months and nobody has fixed it.
- ☐ 8. There are rugs, cords or piles in the walking routes through the house.
- ☐ 9. There's nothing to hold on to in the bathroom.
- ☐ 10. The route from the bed to the bathroom is dark at night.

Medicines

- ☐ 11. There's no one place where all the medicines live.
- ☐ 12. You find pills loose on counters, tables or the floor.
- ☐ 13. They can't tell you what one of their medicines is for.
- ☐ 14. Bottles are running out much faster or much slower than they should.
- ☐ 15. Nobody outside the house has a current list of what they take.

Getting around

- ☐ 16. They hold on to furniture or walls to cross a room.
- ☐ 17. They've had a fall, or you think they've had one they didn't mention.
- ☐ 18. Stairs, the tub, or getting out of a chair have become an event.
- ☐ 19. There are bruises they explain vaguely, or don't explain at all.
- ☐ 20. They've stopped going somewhere they always went.

Money and mail

- ☐ 21. Unopened mail is stacking up.
- ☐ 22. Bills have gone unpaid, or been paid twice.
- ☐ 23. There are charges, subscriptions or gifts you can't account for.
- ☐ 24. Someone new is calling or visiting often, and money is involved.
- ☐ 25. They're vague or defensive about money in a way they never used to be.

How they seem, and reaching them

- ☐ 26. They repeat the same question or story inside one conversation.
- ☐ 27. They've been unsure what day or date it is more than once.
- ☐ 28. They've dropped a hobby, a group, or the friends they used to see.
- ☐ 29. They seem flat, anxious, or angrier than is usual for them.
- ☐ 30. You often can't reach them, and there's nobody nearby you could ask to go and knock on the door.

Anything else you noticed

What to do with this

One check mark is noise. People have bad weeks. What matters is a cluster in one section, or the same item still true in three months.

Take the specifics to their doctor, not the conclusion. "She's had two falls she didn't tell me about and she's lost weight since March" gets further than "I'm worried about my mother." A doctor can also say the thing you can't say without it becoming a fight.

Fix the physical things first. A light on the landing, a bar in the bathroom, the rug that's been curling for a decade. Nobody argues about a light bulb, and these are the items here that are cheapest to close.

Number 30 is the one people skip. Being unreachable is not a small thing when there's nobody within twenty minutes of the front door. If that line is checked and you have no name to call, that's the first gap to close, before any of the others.

If you can't reach them

Item 30 is the one worth closing today, and it takes ten minutes. Write down who lives close enough to walk to the door, and ask them first so the name on this line is a name that has agreed to it.

A neighbor

Someone in the family who lives nearby

Their building, manager or front desk

Their doctor